



“Never in the field of human conflict was so much owed by so many to so few.”

WINSTON CHURCHILL
BRITISH PRIME MINISTER, REFERRING
TO RAF FIGHTER COMMAND,
SEPTEMBER 1940

THE BATTLE FOR BRITAIN

SMALL IN SCALE COMPARED WITH AIR OPERATIONS LATER IN THE WAR, THE BATTLE OF BRITAIN AND THE BLITZ WERE CRUCIAL MOMENTS IN WORLD HISTORY

THE BATTLE OF BRITAIN was raised to heroic status even before it began. On June 18, 1940, Prime Minister Winston Churchill told the House of Commons: “I expect that the Battle of Britain is about to begin. Upon this battle depends the survival of Christian civilization... The whole fury and might of the enemy must very soon be turned on us... Let us therefore brace ourselves to our duties and so bear ourselves that, if the British Empire and the Commonwealth last for a thousand years, men will still say, ‘this was their finest hour.’”

Such grandiloquence invites deflation, and there have been plenty of mockers dedicated to demolishing the “myth of the finest hour.” Yet more than 60 years after the event, the drama of the “Spitfire summer” shows no sign of losing its grip on the popular imagination. It still stands as the first major battle fought entirely in the air, just as the Blitz that followed was the first sustained campaign of strategic bombing.

The Battle of Britain was an aerial contest for which the British had prepared and the Germans had not. Since the mid-1930s the defense of Britain against an attack by the Luftwaffe had been a central focus of British military planning. For the Germans, the campaign was an improvised response to finding themselves, with surprising suddenness, in control of western Europe. Hitler was nervous about invading Britain, but something had to be done to make the British accept that they were beaten. An air offensive seemed to have every advantage. It

might in itself force the British to negotiate a surrender, especially if backed up by the threat of an invasion; and if it went particularly well, the invasion might be possible for real.



WARTIME LEADER

In June 1940, Britain's prime minister Winston Churchill gave the airborne defense of his country its famous name, proclaiming: “The Battle of Britain is about to begin.”

Since early July the RAF and the Luftwaffe had been clashing over the English Channel, as British ports and merchant convoys came under air attack from German

aircraft. The main German onslaught on England, in response to Hitler's directive to the Luftwaffe – “to overcome the British air force with all means at its disposal and in the shortest possible time” – began on August 13. Fleets of bombers, escorted by fighters, carried out daylight raids with special concentration on destroying airfields, aircraft factories, and radar installations. The determined resistance of RAF Spitfires and Hurricanes in the first days of the offensive led the Luftwaffe to focus increasingly on raiding Fighter Command airbases and on wearing down the fighter force in the air. Then on September 7, at a time when Fighter Command was under maximum pressure, the focus of Luftwaffe operations shifted again, turning to mass bombing raids on London. By the end of October the Luftwaffe had given up its dream of air superiority, settling for nighttime bombing raids on London and other British cities – the Blitz.



LEGENDARY FIGHTER

The Supermarine Spitfire entered aviation legend with its performance in the Battle of Britain in 1940. Although not the most numerous aircraft in Fighter Command, it was in many ways the best. Without it, RAF pilots would not have been able to take on the Messerschmitt Bf 109 so successfully.